



ALLIANCE FOR COLLECTIVE EMPOWERMENT AND DEVELOPMENT

PERSONAL & CONFIDENTIAL

Dear Dr. Johnson,

My name is Léandre Poplus, founder of the Alliance for Collective Empowerment and Development, ACE. What you have argued for more than a decade has stayed with me: that Black children, and Black boys in particular, need institutions built by us, for us, culturally rooted and owned outright, not another round of reform inside a system that was never built to educate them.

A country unwilling to treat a people right was never going to teach that people right either. The two withholdings come from the same place. I believe this is why FDMG Academy had to exist, and I believe it is also why ACE has to exist now, not as a request for this country to finally teach us properly, but as the decision to stop waiting for a lesson it was never going to give.

I am not writing to relitigate what happened with FDMG Academy, and nothing that follows should be read as a judgment of its outcome. I am writing because I believe there is a foundational point on which our two agendas move closer together rather than further apart. It rests on a single premise: “A system built to exclude cannot be reformed into one that includes.”

That premise is not only philosophy. It has a cost, and you have already paid a version of it. You have said plainly, in your own words, that no prominent figure in Black America stepped forward to support FDMG Academy in any real capacity. I do not know their reasons. I have my own belief about why, that association with a project already labeled separatist carried a reputational and financial risk few were willing to absorb, particularly those whose revenue depends on comfort with white audiences and institutions. If I am right, it was never a verdict on the merit of the idea. It was a verdict on how exposed anyone becomes the moment they are seen standing beside it.

I raise this not to revisit what happened to FDMG, but because ACE carries the same exposure. The ideology is close enough, and the greater part of Black America is still, in my honest assessment, asleep at the wheel. ACE’s funding model, community



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bonds, tiered ownership, capital that does not wait on a handful of gatekeepers to bless it first, was built with exactly that risk in mind. Whether it is enough remains to be proven. Nothing about it is guaranteed by design alone. I say that plainly because I would rather you hear it from me than discover it on your own: please do not mistake me for an activist, a politician, or a leader in the traditional sense. I do not ascribe to any of those roles.

I would describe myself as an advocate for the improvement, empowerment, and prosperity of Black people, and as someone who has thought critically about our people's past in an effort to help build a different future. I believe no one is better positioned to tell me where that future is still incomplete than someone who has already tried to build a piece of it and can say plainly what would need to go differently the next time.

I am asking you to read the ACE Act, challenge what should be challenged, and tell me plainly whether the model in front of you closes the gap that FDMG fell into, or simply moves the same gap somewhere else.

Please begin with the enclosed Executive Summary and Founding Position, then read the ACE Community and Development Act. I would welcome a direct conversation about what it would take to make this real.

Respectfully,

Léandre Poplus

Founder

Alliance for Collective Empowerment and Development

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